CHAPTER 1

WRITING AND CITY LIFE

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master the emergence of urban civilization in Mesopotamia between the Tigris and Euphrates, cuneiform script evolution, temple institutions (Ziggurats), and the monumental Code of Hammurabi.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Geography and River Valley Ecology:** Mesopotamian urbanization flourished between Tigris and Euphrates; southern fertile alluvium supported productive agriculture, sustained food surplus, and catalyzed specialized trade.

• **Evolution of Cuneiform Script:** Writing emerged around 3200 BCE as administrative recording on clay tablets using reed styluses, evolving from pictographs into wedge-shaped (cuneiform) syllabic script.

• **Urban Architecture and Temple Centers:** Temples (Ziggurats) dedicated to deities (Moon god Nanna of Ur, Inanna goddess of love and war) functioned as economic hubs for grain storage, artisan craft, and redistribution.

• **Legal Codification and Social Stratification:** The Code of Hammurabi established 282 codified laws governing contracts, property, and family relations with retributive justice reflecting rigid class hierarchies.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{Mesopotamian Urban Base} \iff \text{Agricultural Surplus} + \text{Division of Labour} + \text{Water Transport}$$

Three Interdependent Catalysts of Early Urbanism

$$\text{Cuneiform Development} \iff \text{Clay Tablet Impress} \rightarrow \text{Pictographic Tokens} \rightarrow \text{Wedge-Shaped Syllabary}$$

Chronological Evolution of Written Administration

$$\text{Temple Complex Dualism} \rightarrow \{\text{Sacred Deity Worship}, \quad \text{Civic Granary and Economic Nucleus}\}$$

Functional Architecture of the Mesopotamian Ziggurat

$$\text{Code of Hammurabi} \iff 282 \text{ Codified Edicts} \rightarrow \text{Lex Talionis (Eye for an Eye)}$$

Earliest Systematic Statutory Legal Framework

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Mesopotamian tablets were written on damp clay and baked dry in the sun or kilns; once baked, they could not be altered or reused, preserving an immutable historical archive.

• **Alert:** Never confuse southern Babylonia and Sumer (irrigated alluvial plains) with northern Assyria (rolling steppe plateaus suited for pastoral herding).

• **Alert:** Ur lacked town planning; roads were narrow and winding with blind alleys, unlike the grid-iron cities of Mohenjo-Daro.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Name the two rivers that nurtured the Mesopotamian civilization and state what the name 'Mesopotamia' literally means. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Two Rivers:** The Tigris and the Euphrates rivers. **[1 Mark]**

• **Literal Meaning:** Derived from two Greek words: 'mesos' (middle) and 'potamos' (river), meaning the land situated between rivers. **[1 Mark]**

2. Explain the development and significance of writing in ancient Mesopotamia. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Origin and Medium:** Writing began around 3200 BCE on smooth, wet clay tablets using a sharp-edged reed stylus that pressed wedge-shaped marks (cuneiform) before baking hard in the sun. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Administrative Purpose:** Originated to keep numerical records of temple transactions, grain dispatches, livestock inventories, and land transfers. **[1 Mark]**

• **Cultural Significance:** Facilitated the codification of laws (Code of Hammurabi), recording royal deeds, preserving historical epics (Epic of Gilgamesh), and developing mathematical astronomy. **[1.5 Marks]**

3. Describe the role of temples in Mesopotamian urban society. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Religious Role:** Temples (Ziggurats) were residences of deities such as the Moon God of Ur and Inanna (goddess of love and war), built on massive raised mud-brick platforms. **[1 Mark]**

• **Economic Nucleus:** Temples were the central economic institutions of early cities, collecting agricultural produce, conducting oil pressing, grain grinding, spinning, and weaving. **[1 Mark]**

• **Employer and Record Keeper:** Maintained written rosters of rations, commanded merchant trade expeditions, and organized defensive community labour. **[1 Mark]**

4. Highlight any three distinct features of town planning in the ancient city of Ur. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Narrow, Irregular Streets:** Streets were winding and narrow, preventing wheeled carts from reaching houses; grain and goods were transported on pack donkeys. **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Lack of Town Drainage:** Ur lacked a systematic street drainage system like Harappa; household drains emptied into unpaved courtyards or narrow lanes. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Courtyard Housing Architecture:** Windowless exterior walls opened onto an interior central courtyard for domestic privacy and light. **[1 Mark]**

5. What was the Code of Hammurabi? Mention two of its important principles. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Historical Background:** A comprehensive legal code inscribed on an eight-foot diorite stele by King Hammurabi of Babylon around 1750 BCE, containing 282 statutory edicts. **[1 Mark]**

• **Two Important Principles:**
• Principle of Retaliation (Lex Talionis): 'An eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth'.
• Social Class Disparity: Penalties differed sharply depending on whether the victim was a nobleman, a commoner, or an enslaved person. **[2 Marks]**

6. State two major intellectual contributions of Mesopotamia to world civilization. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Contribution 1:** The sexagesimal number system (base 60), dividing the hour into 60 minutes and the circle into 360 degrees. **[1 Mark]**

• **Contribution 2:** Creation of a precise solar and lunar calendar recording eclipses and planetary positions. **[1 Mark]**